UNIT 5

Evolution of Society in South India

Learning Objectives

- To understand the social and political formation in early South India from the third century BCE to the fifth century CE

Introduction

In the Deccan region, encompassing major parts of present day Telangana, Andhra, Karnataka and Maharashtra, the Satavahanas established a powerful kingdom in the first century BCE. In the south, the three family ruling houses, the Cheras, the Cholas and the Pandyas were their contemporaries, ruling the fertile parts of Tamizhagam. But the Tamil rulers started two centuries earlier as they figure in Ashoka's inscriptions of the third century BCE. There were many common things as well as differences in the polity and society of the Deccan and Tamil regions.

Sources

Archaeological

- The megalithic burial sites of the early historic period.
- Excavated material from ancient sites, including ports, capital towns, with architectural remains, such as in Arikamedu, Kodumanal, Alangulam, and Uraiyur.
- Buddhist sites with **stupas** and **chaityas** located in Andhra and Karnataka regions (Amaravati, Nagarjunakonda, etc.)

Numismatic

- Coins of pre-Satavahana chieftains and of the Satavahanas from Andhra-Karnataka region.

Stupas: The stupa is a heap of clay that evolved out of earthen funerary mounds, in which the ashes of the dead were buried. Buddhist stupas evolved out of the burial of the ashes of the mortal remains of the Buddha. Buddhist sacred architecture originated with the eight stupas where the ashes were divided. Hemispherical shape, the stupa symbolizes the universe; and the Buddha represents the emperor of the spiritual universe. The stupa has a path around it for devotional circumambulation.

- The coins issued by the Cheras, Cholas, Pandyas, and the chieftains of the Sangam Age.
- Roman copper, silver and gold coins.

Epigraphic

- The Ashokan inscriptions, written in Prakrit, found in Andhra-Karnataka regions.
- The Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions found in the caves of Tamil Nadu and Kerala such as in Mangulam, Jambai, and Pugalur.
- The Satavahana inscriptions and other Buddhist inscriptions of the Andhra region
- Short inscriptions found on pottery and rings and stones in Tamil Nadu and some sites outside India, like in Berenike, and Quseir al Qadhim (Egypt).

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